

HOMER'S ODYSSEY THREE WAYS: RECENT TRANSLATIONS
BY VERITY, WILSON, AND GREEN

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Verity, A. (tr.) and Allan, W. (intro. and notes) 2016. *Homer: The Odyssey*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Pp. xxx + 354. ISBN 978–0–19–966910–3. £16.99; Wilson, E. (tr.) 2018. *Homer: The Odyssey*. New York: Norton. Pp. x + 582. ISBN 978–0–393–08905–9. US\$39.95; Green, P. (tr.) 2018. *Homer: The Odyssey, A New Translation*. Oakland: University of California Press. Pp. xiv + 522. ISBN 978–0–520–29363–2. US\$29.95.

In the twenty-first century it has become fashionable to apply the term 'translation' to any sort of work recognizably based on an original.¹ Thus one could call 'translations of the *Odyssey*' not only renderings by, say, E.V. Rieu and Richmond Lattimore, but also James Joyce's *Ulysses*, Derek Walcott's *The Odyssey, A Stage Play*, Margaret Atwood's *The Penelopiad*, and perhaps even Romare Bearden's wonderful Odyssean collages.²

I have no quarrel with that. However, if the word 'translation' is to be used in this very broad sense, then we need to distinguish between translations; and such a distinction must be based on the *purpose* for which a translation is made. In the case of the three books under review – two of them published by university presses, the third by a major provider of college textbooks – their leading purpose is clearly to present Homer's *Odyssey* to first-time readers of the epic, and especially to university students as texts for study. Let us call versions of this kind 'academic' translations – meaning by 'academic' only the purpose I have just outlined, and nothing in any sense pejorative – and the other kind 'creative' translations.

Now, of course, any translator will bring their own personality, outlook, store of language, and set of values to their work. But there is still an obvious difference between an 'academic' translation and a 'creative' one, the difference being that creative artists have complete freedom with regard to the

¹ See, for instance, Hardwick 2000:9–22.

² On Bearden, see O'Meally 2007.

text of the *Odyssey*. They may bring any agenda they please to their version. They are perfectly free to transform the ancient epic into a novel or drama, or to make their text all about issues utterly foreign – or only tangential – to Homer’s main concerns. And although prior knowledge of the *Odyssey* may enhance readers’ enjoyment of such versions, those versions are to be judged as autonomous works of art.³

Not so an academic translation of Homer, which must be judged *both* by its fluency as a work in English *and* by its relationship to the Greek original.⁴ For such a version, scholarly precision and accuracy are essential, though not on their own sufficient. The translation has to create an English diction adequate to Homer,⁵ it must be readable, it must hold its target audience’s attention.

Of the three *Odyssey* translations under review, Emily Wilson’s is certainly the most unusual, and will therefore receive the most attention here. Her version appeared amid a barrage of positive publicity. The great and the good endorsed the work. In my judgement, however, Wilson has not produced an academic translation – i.e. one suitable to be recommended to first-time readers, or to undergraduate students of epic – though it may interest readers who already know the *Odyssey*, or those concerned with translation as a process.

The two great novelties of Wilson’s *Odyssey* are the way she represents a group of characters that we might term ‘underdogs’ – notably the Cyclops,

³ For their part, from what source would Greekless ‘creatives’ and readers get such ‘prior knowledge’ of Homer, if not from the sort of translation I have termed ‘academic’? Of James Joyce his close friend Frank Budgen wrote: ‘As a work of reference for his *Ulysses* he used the Butcher-Lang translation of the *Odyssey*’ (Budgen 1972:359); while for *War Music*, Christopher Logue’s twentieth-century take on Homer, the poet used, among others, the literal English of A.T. Murray’s Loeb *Iliad*, and E.V. Rieu’s translation (Hardwick 2000:57).

⁴ In a review of works about Greek culture by Arnold Toynbee, the reviewer Frederic Manning commented drily that it was ‘advisable that a translator from Greek into English should know at least one of the two languages with which he [sic] deals’ (Eliot and Haughton 2009:454 n. 4).

⁵ I would say that finding an appropriate and consistent English diction is one of the hardest tasks for the Homeric translator. Alexander Pope makes some acute remarks on this: ‘Nothing that belongs to *Homer* seems to have been more commonly mistaken than the just Pitch of his Style: some of his Translators having swell’d into Fustian [bombastic would-be grandeur] in a proud Confidence of the *Sublime*; others sunk into Flatness in a cold and timorous Notion of *Simplicity*’ (Mack 1967:18; Pope’s italics).

and the suitors and their allies – in a sympathetic light,⁶ while representing Odysseus as, on balance, reprehensible. The big problem, however, with Wilson's heterodox approach to the characters of the *Odyssey* is that she can sustain it only by distorting and misrepresenting what the Greek text says.

For Wilson, the *Odyssey* 'to some extent'⁷ glorifies its protagonist', but far more importantly Odysseus is, for her, not heroic,⁸ but 'this liar, pirate, colonizer, deceiver, and thief' within whose sphere 'other people – those he owns, those he leads – suffer and die, and who directly kills so many people' (p. 66).⁹ And she loses no opportunity to translate in such a way as to reinforce this. One example: Odysseus' possible culpability for the death of some of his comrades is a persistent underlying issue in the epic,¹⁰ but Wilson wants to make him directly, criminally responsible for the demise of *all* his men, and so she forces the text of the *Odyssey* to mean what she wants it to mean. Consider her version of *Od.* 1.5–9¹¹ when the poet's authorial voice, which should carry some authority, speaks on this matter:

⁶ In her acknowledgments Wilson thanks educators who 'taught me to look for the stories and voices of losers in epic' (p. 581).

⁷ Italics throughout this article are mine, except where otherwise stated, or where they are obviously used by someone else for a purpose such as indicating a book title.

⁸ Wilson is selective and idiosyncratic in her treatment of the term ἥρως ('hero'). Wanting to put the emphasis on violence, she sometimes renders it 'warrior' or 'warlike' (15.63; 21.300; 24.68), but leaves it out when the Greek uses the term of Odysseus' allies (Menelaus, 15.121; Laertes, 24.135). Wilson *does* use the term, where the Greek doesn't, in the following instances: of Odysseus, when he is at his lowest ebb, 'Half-starved and weak, the hero ate and drank' (7.177, for αὐτὰρ ὁ πῖνε καὶ ἦσθε πολύτλας δῖος Ὀδυσσεύς); of the giants Otus and Ephialtes whom she calls 'heroes' (11.309–10, seemingly for πολὺ καλλίστους); of certain suitors, 'the most heroic of the group' (22.244, μνηστήρων ἀρετῇ ἔσαν ἔξοχ' ἄριστοι).

⁹ I think Wilson gets this precisely the wrong way around. While I don't believe that either the *Iliad* or the *Odyssey* 'glorifies' its leading characters, the *Odyssey*, in my view, is clearly designed to make the audience sympathize with Odysseus, and only 'to some extent' lets us know that he is a 'hero' of the ancient – not the modern – kind, a flawed individual with a dubious, dark side to his nature (Whitaker 2017:54–59).

¹⁰ The poem raises the issue right at the start: *Od.* 1.5–9; also *Od.* 9.224–30; 10.435–37; 24.426–28.

¹¹ The line numbers of Wilson's translation may differ by as many as four lines from the line numbering of the Greek text. If I am referring specifically to the latter, I do so in the form '*Od.* 3.311'.

[Odysseus] worked to save his life and bring his men back home. He failed to keep them safe; poor fools, they ate the Sun God's cattle, and the god kept them from home. (1.6–9)

Where the Greek says ἀλλ' οὐδ' ὥς (*Od.* 1.6; 'yet' or 'even so' [despite his efforts]) Odysseus could not save his men, Wilson leaves out this important qualification. And then, with breathtaking insouciance, she simply omits to translate the key phrase 'though he *longed* to [sc. save them]' (*Od.* 1.6) as well as, in its entirety, the crucial line: 'it was *through their own blind recklessness that they* [his men] *perished*' (*Od.* 1.7).¹² Finally, where the Greek says the sun god actively 'took away' [ἀφείλετο, 1.9] their homecoming', i.e. destroyed the men because of their 'recklessness', Wilson obscures this with her misleading 'kept them from home'.¹³

Further, Wilson repeatedly tries to prejudice her readers against Odysseus in subtle and not so subtle ways. At the very start of Odysseus' long narrative of his wanderings, she warns the reader against believing anything that may follow by extracting from πολύμητις¹⁴ (the hero's stock epithet), 'Wily Odysseus, *the lord of lies*' (9.1). Again, 'lying Odysseus' at 24.303 for πολύμητις.¹⁵ Wilson also trivializes the actions and emotions of the hero. Compare the accurate translations of Green or Verity with Wilson's in the following instances, where Odysseus is the speaker or agent: *Od.* 8.233–34: 'aboard my ship I had no long-term care for my body' (Green) – 'upon the raft / I could not do my exercise routine' (Wilson); *Od.* 9.52–53: 'then an evil fate from Zeus stood close to us, / ill-fated as we were, and caused us to suffer many torments' (Verity) – for all of which Wilson gives us, 'Then Zeus / gave us bad luck. Poor us!'; *Od.* 22.283: 'Odysseus, sacker of cities, struck Eury-

¹² Green's translation; Verity: 'since they perished by reason of their own recklessness'.

¹³ In addition, right through the epic, when the recurrent phrase ὀλέσας ἀπο πάντας ἐταίρους (or similar) is used of Odysseus, Wilson distorts its meaning. Every one of the many English versions of the poem that I have consulted translates ὀλέσας 'having lost' (all his companions), implying ill fate or misfortune. But Wilson translates 'having caused / the death of all your men' (9.534–35; 12.143–44); 'having destroyed your men' (11.117); '[Odysseus] lost his ship / ... and let his loyal men be killed' (19.272–73). But why, one has to ask, would Odysseus, who is the narrator in all three places, *inculcate himself* in this way?

¹⁴ Green: 'resourceful'; Verity: 'of many wiles'.

¹⁵ In similar vein, from another stock epithet of Odysseus, πολύτλας (Green: 'much-enduring'), Wilson manages to get 'hardened' (23.110) and 'ruthless' (24.349).

damas' (Verity) – 'The city-sacker / skewered Eurydamas' (Wilson).¹⁶ Finally, Wilson consistently exaggerates the violence and blameworthiness of Odysseus' actions. Just two instances out of many will have to suffice. While Green (accurately) has Odysseus threaten the beggar Irus, 'I [will] spatter your breast and lips / with your blood' (*Od.* 18.21–22), Wilson, following her own agenda, ramps this up to, 'I will crack your ribs and smash your face / to bloody pulp'. Later, when the suitors have been killed, Wilson has Odysseus *himself*, most implausibly, talk of their killing as 'murder' (23.115, 136; Green: 'killed', 'slaughter'; Verity: 'kills', 'slaying').

In strong contrast, Wilson does her best to play down the wrongdoing of Odysseus' adversaries. Of the suitors, she argues that '[g]reed, ingratitude, and rudeness are annoying but ... rather trivial faults'; the suitors may be 'boorish, selfish, immature young men' and 'unpleasant to be around', but 'the murdered boys'¹⁷ perhaps didn't really deserve to die (p. 28). (Wilson fails to mention that the suitors actively attempt to kill Telemachus.) And by dubious renderings of the Greek she seeks to reinforce this interpretation. Again, the point is best made by comparing Wilson's with more accurate translations. *Od.* 16.410 speaks of the suitors' ὑπέρβιον ὕβριν, which Wilson translates far too mildly as 'ungentlemanly suitors' – Verity: 'men of violent insolence'; Green: 'so outrageous and arrogant'). *Od.* 17.587–88: 'There never were such bullies as [the suitors], / and they intend us harm' (Wilson) – 'never yet among mortal mankind have there been men / who plot such arrogant and reckless violence' (Verity); *Od.* 24.282: 'cruel men' (Wilson) – 'outrageous and reckless men' (Green). Then, in her summary of the action of Book Twenty-four, Wilson writes that the suitors 'behaved badly' (p. 551), where the relevant line of the poem talks of men who '[i]n their criminal folly ... perpetrated a monstrous wrong' (Green's rendering of *Od.* 24.458).

Translating in the same tendentious manner, Wilson would have us view Polyphemus the Cyclops as a sort of prelapsarian pastoralist, more sinned against – by a devious, violent, proto-colonizing Odysseus – than sinning; though Polyphemus *does* have 'the nasty habit of eating his human visitors' (p. 22). The chapter title she gives to *Odyssey* Book Nine, 'A Pirate in a Shepherd's Cave' begins the work of directing our sympathies. And numerous tweaks and twists continue that work. When Odysseus retrospectively char-

¹⁶ And what to say of the hero's dead mother addressing him, in Wilson's version, as 'Odysseus, my sunshine' (*Od.* 11.202; Green: 'illustrious'; Verity: 'brilliant')?

¹⁷ To evoke pathos and sympathy for the suitors, Wilson likes to suggest that they are hardly more than adolescents. She translates 'watch as the boys [Greek: 'suitors'] who swagger here are killed' (*Od.* 20.233–34); and when the suitors' ringleader Antinous is about to die she inserts '[t]he young man', where the Greek simply says 'he' (*Od.* 22.9). Cf. 'the boys ... [Odysseus] has slaughtered' (p. 85).

acterizes the Cyclops as ‘a man clothed in huge strength, / a savage’¹⁸ with no understanding of either justice or laws’ (*Od.* 9.214–15, Verity), Wilson translates: ‘a man of courage, wild, / and lacking knowledge of the normal customs’. So too, although Homeric πέλωρ and πελώριον always connote monstrosity, often together with great size,¹⁹ when the terms are used of Polyphemus Wilson renders them just as ‘massive’ or ‘giant’ (*Od.* 9.187, 190 and 257; ‘monstrous’, Green and Verity). Wilson deals similarly with Greek words expressing condemnation. After the Cyclops’ first act of cannibalism, Odysseus says σχέτλια ἔργ’ ὀρώωντες (*Od.* 9.295), which Green translates ‘at the sight of such bestial deeds’, but Wilson neutrally, ‘[w]atching this disaster’, as if σχέτλια were morally neutral; in similar vein she renders νηλεῖ θυμῷ, of the Cyclops, ‘[u]nmoved’ (*Od.* 9.272; ‘with pitiless heart’, Green). At *Od.* 9.442 where ‘fool’ (νήπιος), and *Od.* 20.20 where ‘unrestrained in fury’ (μένος ἄσχετος; ‘savage’, Rieu; ‘ruthless’, Shewring) are used of the Cyclops, she simply omits to translate.

I apologize to the reader for dwelling so much on detail, but in the case of Wilson’s translation that is where the devil lies.

Another innovation of Wilson’s *Odyssey* is its handling of slavery. She asserts: ‘[t]he need to acknowledge the fact and the horror of slavery, and to mark the fact that the idealized society depicted in the [*Odyssey*] is one where slavery is shockingly taken for granted, seems to me to outweigh the need to specify, in every instance, the type of slave’ (pp. 88–89).²⁰ Adopting a policy of what one might call ‘Pan-Slaveism’, Wilson translates as ‘slave’

¹⁸ Wilson eschews ‘savage’ which for her carries a ‘legacy of ... colonialism ... anachronistic in the world of *The Odyssey*’ (p. 88).

¹⁹ Only monstrosity (and not large size) is connoted by πέλωρ at *Od.* 10.219 (Circe’s wolves and lions which fawn on men); and probably also by πελώρου at *Od.* 11.634 (the Gorgon).

²⁰ Wilson thus places herself in a long line of critics stretching back via William Gladstone and Plato to Xenophanes, all of whom used moral criteria to judge Homer. I must say, though, that I have never found moral outrage a useful starting point from which to approach Homeric (or any other) poetry. Consider, for instance, Gladstone on *Od.* 3.466–67. My translation: ‘When *she* [Nestor’s daughter] *had bathed and rubbed him* [Telemachus] with olive oil, / *she dressed him* in a ... cloak’ (tr. Whitaker 2017 *ad loc.*). But contrary to the plain sense of the Greek, Gladstone wants these lines to mean: ‘[*she*] *had* Telemachus wash *himself*. / When *he* *had* washed and rubbed his skin with oil / *he* dressed up in a ... cloak’ (Gladstone 1858:514). The British Prime Minister, thinking it incredible that Homer could be guilty of the shocking impropriety of allowing an elite woman (‘of the highest rank and character’) to bathe a male visitor, concluded: ‘And, as it is not credible, so neither, I think, is it true’ (*ibid.*).

(or ‘house girl / boy’) a whole range of distinct Greek words for non-elite serving men and women: ‘maidservant’ (ἄμφίπολος), ‘steward’ (οἰνόχοος), ‘old man’ (γέρων), ‘(old) woman’ (γρηὺς / γύνη), ‘nurse’ (τροφός), ‘chambermaid’ (θαλαμηπόλος), ‘honourable / well-born men’ (ἄνδρες ἑσθλοί),²¹ ‘housekeeper’ (ταμίη),²² ‘shepherd’ (ποιμήν),²³ and ‘guardian’ (ἐπίουρος).²⁴ Wilson is simply wrong, though, when she uses ‘slave’ (as she often does) to render θεραπῶν (‘attendant’ or ‘squire’) and κήρυξ (‘herald’).²⁵ But when her wrongheaded interpretation of the herald’s status might get her into difficulties, she simply abandons it, though her confusion is apparent from her uncertainty about terms. Thus, at *Od.* 2.38, when the herald Peisenor handles the sceptre at the Ithacan assembly, Wilson translates κήρυξ as ‘[t]he competent official’²⁶ (presumably because a slave could hardly have participated in assembly proceedings). And she renders *Od.* 19.244–47: ‘[Odysseus] had a [κήρυξ] ... Eurybates ... / who had black skin ... woolly hair’. Wilson (with good reason) takes Eurybates to be of African origin but translates κήρυξ here not as ‘slave’, as she does almost everywhere else, but ‘valet’.²⁷

Moving on to matters of style: Wilson tries hard to make her translation thoroughly contemporary by using simple, everyday, colloquial language – not only in speeches, where Homer too sometimes uses intimate and col-

²¹ Wilson takes the words to mean ‘trained slaves’ (3.471).

²² Ταμίη: ‘slave girl’ (Wilson 4.55 and *passim*). But when the male equivalent ταμίης occurs in Book 10 she has to translate differently, because this is Aeolus whom Zeus made ‘steward of the winds’ (Wilson 10.21).

²³ Ποιμήν: ‘slave’ (Wilson 4.86). Yet she translates the equivalent ἐπιβώτορι μῆλων as ‘shepherd’ at 13.222. Why? Because the shepherd in Book 13 is Athena in princely disguise.

²⁴ Writing on slavery, Thalmann points out that Homer, despite being well aware of the δουλ- root (often employed in the phrase δούλιον ἥμαρ), tends to avoid words unambiguously meaning ‘slave’; he suggests that this ‘may be part of a tendency to mitigate the actual harshness of a relation of domination, which is generally revealed only indirectly’ (Thalmann 2011:809). Because it obscures this significant feature of the epic, Wilson’s translation, ironically, could not be used for research into ‘slavery in Homer’s *Odyssey*’.

²⁵ Raaflaub 2011:811 classes θεραπῶντες (‘retainers’) among ‘dependent but free persons’; while Thalmann – no apologist for slavery – points out that heralds (κήρυκες) ‘[s]everal times ... are called θεραπῶντες’, and views them thus as ‘members of the elite but subordinate to more powerful men’ (Thalmann 2011:346).

²⁶ Though her glossary s.v. ‘Pisenor’ calls him ‘Telemachus’ *herald*’.

²⁷ One can only speculate why ‘valet’ (a *hapax* in her translation) rather than ‘slave’; fear of giving offence, perhaps? In her glossary s.v. ‘Eurybates’ Wilson styles him ‘squire of Odysseus’.

loquial terms²⁸ – but also, often, in narrative, where he hardly ever uses them. Here is a small sample of her colloquial diction: ‘You must be joking’ (1.64); ‘babysit’ (7.12); ‘She looked astonishing’ (8.367); ‘whooshed’ (10.55); ‘snuggling’ (10.218); ‘cutest’ (10.278); ‘Teenagers’ (11.38); ‘pointless to talk of hypotheticals’ (11.465); ‘she glugs it down’ (12.106); ‘tote bag’ (13.438); ‘cushy’ (14.47); ‘make nice’ (14.387); ‘standoffishness’ (15.72); ‘games of darts’ (17.168); ‘cottoned on’ (18.95); ‘pace themselves’ (21.295, of drinking wine); and ‘fluffy pillows’ (24.257). Occasionally, though, Wilson uses a higher register of language that I feel clashes with her otherwise plain and colloquial diction. For instance: ‘vernal Dawn’ (5.228); ‘seven days and ten’ (5.277); ‘fleet-foot deer’ (6.104); ‘wreathed about by boundless sea’ (10.195); ‘Truly now their day / of doom is near at hand’ (16.280–81); ‘with dangers compassed round’ (17.526); ‘Mentor, for shame!’ (2.242). At one point the two levels collide jarringly: ‘mighty Zeus, the god of home owners’ (22.335).

The metre Wilson uses for her translation is a strict ten-syllable iambic pentameter, allowing an unstressed eleventh syllable (as in lines 116, 117, 122 and 123 of the passage quoted immediately below). At their best, her chosen diction and metre move action or description briskly forward:

A distance from this island is another,
across the water, slantways from the harbor,
level and thickly wooded. Countless goats
live there but people never visit it.
No hunters labor through its woods to scale
its hilly peaks. There are no flocks of sheep,
no fields of plowland – it is all untilled,
unsown and uninhabited by humans.
Only the bleating goats live there and graze. (9.116–24)

The problem for Wilson is that ordinary English prose falls very easily into iambic pentameter, so that, in the absence of rhyme (hardly an option for a contemporary translator) or recognizably poetic language and phrasing, the line between prose and what is presented as poetry is extremely thin, almost non-existent. Take this rendering of the first sentences of *Odyssey* Book Eleven, in almost perfect pentameters:

Our first task, when we came down to the sea
and reached our ship, was to run her into

²⁸ For instance, κριὲ πέπον (*Od.* 9.447: ‘Dear ram’ [Green]); ἄττα (*Od.* 16.31: ‘old fellow’ [Green]); μαῖα φίλη (*Od.* 23.59: ‘Nanny dear’ [Verity]) – all in dialogue.

the good salt water and put the mast and
sails on board. We then picked up the sheep
we found there and stowed them in the vessel. (*Od.* 11.1–4)

But this quotation comes verbatim from E.V. Rieu's prose translation of the epic, just divided into lines. In fact, Wilson's vocabulary and style – for the most part plain and flat, often prosaic – remind me of nothing so much as Rieu's relentlessly 1940s-contemporary, ordinary-language prose translation of the *Odyssey*.

Wilson seems to me to misjudge Homer's style. She writes in her introduction: '*The Odyssey* relies on coordinated, not subordinated syntax ("and then this, and then this, and then this")' (p. 83). Homer *does* occasionally compose like that. But he often makes use of a much wider range of 'connectives' – participles that subordinate one verbal phrase to another; numerous particles; words meaning 'since', 'for', 'but', 'if', 'even if' – than Wilson allows. Take the following passage – one among many that she translates in excessively staccato fashion, as a string of unconnected sentences:

Unflappable Odysseus said, "Yes,
I thought of that. You go, I will stay here.
I have been hit before. I know hard knocks.
I am resilient. I suffered war
and being lost at sea. So let this be.
There is no way to hide a hungry belly.
It is insistent ..." (17.282–88)

The only connective Wilson employs here is 'So', although the Greek in the above passage uses γὰρ δὲ, ἀλλ(ά), δ(έ) twice, γάρ, ἐπεὶ, and quasi-relative ἦ.²⁹

Finally on matters of style, Wilson chooses (as had E.V. Rieu) not to observe Homeric repetition of longer passages or of single lines introducing speech, but instead to render them differently each time they occur.³⁰ As

²⁹ It is not the case that Wilson's short ten- or eleven-syllable line allows insufficient room for such connectives. Here are English lines of the same length that *do* represent them: 'Patient, godlike Odysseus answered him: / "I know – you speak to one *who* understands. / *But* you go first *and* I'll wait here outside. / I'm not unused to blows, things thrown at me; / my spirit's strong, *for* I have suffered much / in war and on the sea – so, let come what may! / *But* no one can contain the belly – raging, / *deadly, that* brings great suffering on men ..."' (tr. Whitaker 2017 *ad loc.*).

³⁰ Wilson suggests that: 'In a highly literate society such as our own, repetitions are likely to feel like moments to skip. They can be a mark of writerly laziness ... and

regards lines introducing speech, this has the advantage for her that she can suggest the psychological state, as she interprets it, of a speaker in different contexts. Thus, for example, from the Greek for ‘said’, plus πεπνυμένος, usually translated ‘prudent’ or ‘thoughtful’, the stock epithet for Telemachus (‘T.’ in what follows), Wilson can extract: ‘T. said moodily’ (1.230); ‘T. was brooding’ (1.306); ‘His mind alert and focused, T. replied’ (1.388–89); ‘T. insisted, breathing hard’ (2.130), ‘T. was thoughtful but not shy’ (3.74–75); and so on. Wilson does the same with the stock epithets of all the characters of the *Odyssey*, major as well as minor. In a moment of brilliance (that had me reflecting ‘Why didn’t I think of that!’) she once translates the common epithet εὐπλόκαμος (‘well-braided’) as ‘Demeter with the cornrows in her hair’ (5.125).

I get the distinct impression that Wilson forged ahead translating in linear fashion, seldom looking back to cross-check her differing versions of very similar or identical passages. And this sometimes leads her into error.³¹

In her acknowledgments, Wilson thanks ‘a team of classicist readers whose eagle eyes saved me from innumerable infelicities’ (p. 581). Unfortunately, far too many errors remain, for which she and her publisher Norton must take responsibility.³² Any translator of a text as long and complex as the *Odyssey* is going to err. But in addition to the usual typos, Wilson makes

can send a reader to sleep’ (p. 84). I am not sure this is true. It is certainly untrue of the work of the contemporary poet, Alice Oswald. In *Memorial*, her ‘translation of the *Iliad*’s atmosphere’ (Oswald 2011:1), she repeatedly achieves effects of great power by translating a Homeric simile and then immediately echoing it in identical words.

³¹ For instance: (i) In the long, repeated passage *Od.* 4.333–50 + 4.556–60 = 17.124–46, Odysseus is said to have wrestled a man whose name Wilson gives first, correctly, as ‘Philomeleides’ (4.343), then, wrongly, as ‘Philomedes’ (17.135). And this generates a confusing entry in her glossary, at p. 571: ‘**Philomeleides** ... : mythical king of Lesbos ... In 17.135, he is known as Philomedes’ (p. 571). (The comment of S. West is apposite: ‘The scholia record a variant, corrupted to Φιλομήδης; we can only conjecture what this conceals’ [Heubeck *et al.* 1988: on *Od.* 4.342–44]). (ii) At the end of *Od.* 2, when Telemachus takes ship for Pylos, accompanied by Athena, we get the phrase ἡ δ’ ἔθεν κατὰ κύμα, literally, ‘she ran down the wave’. Wilson translates this, bizarrely, as: ‘The goddess surfed the waves’ (p. 33; though rendered ‘the goddess rode the waves’ on p. 134). But at *Il.* 1.479–83 ἡ δ’ ἔθεν κατὰ κύμα is part of a very similar ‘sailing theme’ where ‘she’ can refer only to the *ship*, since no goddess is involved there. (iii) Wilson fails to notice the significant cross-reference between *Od.* 22.290–91 and 20.296–302 (see last item in n. 34, below).

³² I have drawn up an eight-page list of corrigenda that I have sent to Norton. Any reader wishing to correct their own copy of Wilson can get the list from me.

so many mistakes that, collectively, they begin to sap the reader's confidence in her translation. Straightforward blunders include attributing a speech to the wrong speaker, producing a character formerly unknown to the *Odyssey*, and misidentifying another.³³ Among Wilson's other infelicities are numerous mistranslations,³⁴ lines skipped by the translator,³⁵ and mistakes of fact.³⁶

³³ Speech misattributed: *Od.* 16.434–47 is a speech by the suitor *Eurymachus*, not Antinous (the 'He' of Wilson 16.437). Unknown character: Wilson contrives to split the single character, Eteoneus son of Boethoös (*Od.* 4.22 and 31; 15.95 and 140) into two different individuals, 'Eteoneus' and 'Boethedes' [sic] (presumably for 'Boethoïdes'); her glossary presents two separate characters: '**Eteoneus** (*e-tee-o'-nee-us*): Menelaus' guard in Sparta. 4.22' (p. 562), and '**Boethoedes** (*boh-ee'-thoy-deez*): slave in Menelaus' household. 15.138' (p. 558). Misidentification: the character at Wilson 24.104 should be 'Melaneus', not 'Menelaus'.

³⁴ Mistranslations: *πεντηκόσιοι* means 'five hundred' not 'fifty' (3.7); *εὐρώνεντα* (from *εὐρύς*, 'mould') means 'dank' or 'mouldy', not 'spacious' (10.513) or 'open' (24.11), as if deriving from *εὐρύς*, 'wide', 'broad'; in *Ἰθάκην στεῖραν βοῦν* (*Od.* 10.522), the adj. *στεῖραν* should not be taken with *Ἰθάκην* and translated 'barren Ithaca' (10.523); 'sword' should be 'spear' at 16.441 and 20.306, while 'dagger' (21.340) should be 'spear' or 'javelin'; 'tomorrow' (17.254) should be 'today'; *δμῶες μυρίοι* are *male*, not 'slave girls' (19.79); *νιφόεντα* does not mean 'cloudy' (19.339), as if from *νέφος*, but 'snowy' (from *νιφάς*); *υἱέες Αὐτολύκοιο* are not Odysseus' *cousins* (19.414 and 464; 21.220) but his uncles; *ὄπλον νεὸς ἀμφιερίσης* (Green: 'a shapely vessel's / cable') does not mean 'fresh-knotted cable' (21.392), apparently taking *νεὸς* for the differently-accented *νέος*, 'new', and the *-ερίσης* part of *ἀμφιερίσης* for 'knotted'; *τοῦτό τοι ἀντὶ ποδὸς ξεινήϊον* is not 'This is a gift to pay you for that kick / you gave Odysseus' (22.290–1) but 'that 'ox hoof you flung' (Wilson has missed the cross-reference back to *Od.* 20.296–302 and has confused the suitor Ctesippus with the goatherd Melanthius, who *does* kick Odysseus, at *Od.* 17.233).

³⁵ I found the following lines untranslated (all line references are to the Greek text): *Od.* 1.7; 7.127–28; 15.241; 16.343–44. Of some consequence is Wilson's failure to translate words of Penelope's dream (*Od.* 19.539–40: '[the dead geese] lay scattered / all over the hall, while the eagle soared up in the bright sky' [Green]) that anticipate the suitors' destruction by her husband; and *Od.* 22.388, which she omits at 22.388–89 of her translation, though she includes the line in her introduction: 'The sun shines down and takes their life away' (p. 85). A related, slightly different, issue: in the lines numbered 16.41–50 there are only *nine* instead of ten lines of text.

³⁶ Mistakes of fact: in Pylos, the guest is not washed by 'slave women' (p. 25); only Telemachus is bathed there, by the (presumably free-born) daughter of Nestor (*Od.* 3.464–65); 'the epithet *διοτρεφής*, "sprung from Zeus"' is not 'applied exclusively to Odysseus' (pp. 31–32), but also to Menelaus (e.g. *Od.* 4.26, 44, 138 etc.), to the leaders

It seems to me that in her handling of the *Odyssey* and its characters and values Wilson is trying to do too many things at once: to rework the *Odyssey* so that it embodies twenty-first-century mores and values; *and* to be a critic;³⁷ *and* to produce a translation suitable for undergraduates and first-time readers of the epic. But her version does not show enough creative independence to stand on its own as a rewriting of the *Odyssey*. And it is marred by too many idiosyncracies and failures of scholarship to succeed as an academic translation.

So far I have used the accurate translations of Verity and Green as foils for Wilson's departures. But of course accuracy and closeness to the original, though prerequisites for an academic version, do not on their own make a good translation.

Green's *Odyssey* opens with an uneven, quirky introduction seemingly aimed at expert Homerists rather than Greekless undergraduates. The latter would be baffled by his lengthy discussion of narrative 'implausibility' and 'inconsistencies' in the *Odyssey* (redolent of long-outmoded nineteenth-century 'Analytic' criticism); pages on the intricate problems of the mythological 'chronology' of rulers at Mycenae (pp. 15–17); and explanations of quantitative verse using terms such as 'position', 'ictus', 'resolvable' and 'catalectic'. And though it could be familiar to them from a TV series like *Mad Men*, twenty-first-century readers might be taken aback by Green's occasional, old-fashioned, laddish sexism.³⁸

They will likely also find the vocabulary of Green's version sometimes odd or stiffly archaic. For instance: 'wroth with' (1.74), 'wrath ... of a mighty sire' (3.135), 'Zeus forfend' (4.699), 'raiment' (8.366), 'not issueless are the

of the Phaeacians (*Od.* 7.49), and even once to the suitor Agelaus (*Od.* 22.136); p. 556: 'Amphilochus' and not 'Antilochus' is the 'son of Amphiaraus [sic]' (for 'Amphiaraus'); p. 573: the island Samē (later Cephallonia), neighbouring Ithaca, is not 'in the eastern Aegean' (confusion with Samos?), but in the *Ionian Sea* off western Greece. (The first edition of Wilson's *Odyssey* gave Richard Bentley's date for Homer as 'about 10,000 BCE', in later printings corrected to '1,000' [p. 8].)

³⁷ Wilson wants her translation 'to allow the reader to see the cracks and fissures in [the *Odyssey*]'s constructed fantasy' (p. 88).

³⁸ Cf. Green's description of Odysseus' stay with Calypso: 'For a marooned sailor, he [Odysseus] has not done badly: seven years, no less, of luxurious cohabitation with a sexy nymph, who ... feeds and sleeps with him ... (5.135–36) ... But now he wants to go home. Why? ... Because (5.153) "the nymph no longer pleased him." Our hero may long for wife and home, but chiefly because he has, very literally, a case of the seven-year itch' (pp. 5–6). And Green translates *Od.* 15.421–22: '[he] made love to her, a thing that fuddles the senses / of truly feminine women, even one that's well-behaved.'

couplings / of the immortals' (11.249–50), 'reproved him in shameful wise' (18.321), 'comely bedfellow' (23.91); while 'gaily' – as in 'our finest dancers / foot it gaily' (8.250–51) and 'laughing gaily' (18.111) – will hardly bear its intended meaning for readers under about forty.

Another archaic feature of Green's translation is his fondness for 'poetic' inversions (sometimes with more than a touch of the *Star Wars* character Yoda about them): 'Guest-friends of each other Odysseus and I claim we are' (1.187) or 'Back home now indeed I am!' (21.207).

Despite these reservations, though, I found Green's *Odyssey* to be the strongest, most readable, and most sensitive to language and rhythm of the three translations. His version has a weight and dignity to it. This short sample, describing Odysseus' killing of a stag, will illustrate the translation's qualities:

But as I went, and came close to my well-curved vessel,
then, too, some god, seeing me alone, felt pity,
and sent, right into my path, a huge high-antlered stag
on his way from his forest range to drink at the river,
since the sun's strong heat had got to him. As he emerged,
I speared him, in mid-back, piercing his spine: the bronze
spear now transfixed him, he uttered a dying cry
and collapsed in the dust. The spirit fled from him. (10.156–63)

Both Green and Verity use a long, six-beat line. This has the advantage for them that they can translate almost every word of the Greek original. But it also, sometimes, leads to a wordiness, a certain turgidity in their versions that makes one sigh for the concision of Wilson. An example (*Od.* 18.148–50): 'for not bloodless, I think, / will be the final reckoning between that man and the suitors, / once he's made it home and is under his own roof' (Green); 'when he returns to his dear native land ... / I do not think that he and the suitors will settle their differences / without bloodshed, once he has come under his own roof' (Verity); 'when he comes ... / [w]hen he confronts the suitors in this hall / there will be blood' (Wilson).

William Allan's concise introduction to Verity's translation provides first-time readers of the *Odyssey* with exactly the sort of information they need about the epic, its central character, mortals and immortals, the importance of hospitality, and familial relations in the poem. Written in clear, simple English this is by far the best of the introductions to the respective versions.

As for the translation itself, although he presents it in numbered lines, Verity says that his version 'does not claim to be "poetic".' The translator acknowledges that 'some readers may find the occasional shift from current

to archaic idiom awkward' (p. xxvi). Among such readers, I'd imagine, would be contemporary undergraduates, who might baulk at 'what a word has escaped the barrier of your teeth' (1.64 – so too, Green), 'holding revels ... in utter heedlessness' (2.56–57), 'disparage your manliness' (8.240), 'shameless trollop' (8.319), 'dolefully ... compassing his senses about' (8.540–41), and 'a good man and a wealthy' (18.127).

As an example of Verity's translation, here is the opening of *Od.* Book Twenty-two:

Odysseus of many wiles threw back his rags, and leapt
on to the great threshold, holding the bow and quiver
full of arrows; and there he spilled the swift shafts,
right in front of his feet, and addressed the suitors:
'This terrible contest has now come to its end! But this
time I shall shoot at another mark, one that no man has
yet hit – if I can hit it, and if Apollo grants my prayer.'

Verity's translation produces no fireworks. Though accurate and worthy it is often, I have to say, a little dull. But as a whole, his *Odyssey* earns the reader's respect as a careful, straightforward rendering of the original in mostly plain, direct English.

I mentioned at the beginning of this review that all three of these *Odysseys* come from academic publishers. This, and the fact that they all have exactly the same number of lines as the Homeric Greek text, clearly show that they are meant for use in the classroom. They are, in other words, 'academic' translations, and it is on this basis that I have assessed them.

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